

Siva Kumar,
Senior General Manager,
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Prudent printers

How did the printer market fare during the pandemic? We get the details

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The entire consumer gadgets space saw a dramatic surge in demand which led to device manufacturers innovating to bring unique solutions to the market. Printers, as a category, were no different. Whether it was for office or for academic work, printers became very important. To know more, we had a chat with Siva Kumar, Senior General Manager, Epson India.

Q How was the pandemic for Epson on a global level as well as at the local level?

The first wave came as a big opportunity for Epson due to the shift to a work-from-home setup and also because of the e-learning opportunities. Even in the second wave, demand remained stable because of these two factors. Pre-pandemic, the market size was 800K units/year in India for home inkjet printers but during the pandemic, the market touched 1 million units/year. As of today, the market is stable at 950K-1 million units/year. To avoid screen time

students and people working from home were using printers. It is easier for everyone to read and highlight text on a hard copy. This increased the demand for printers at home.

People often have this misconception that digital work will make printer demand go down, but both of them grew almost in the same proportion. The need to reduce screen time and work from home culture has kept the printer market stable, not just in India, but also globally.

Q Have you noticed the customers becoming more tech savvy while making purchases considering all the different technologies that are available to them?

As days go by, technology develops. As a product, a printer, or a multifunction printer, the basic function will remain the same. Only thing is, it is going to advance in terms of connectivity. Major products sold in the multifunction category are still the non Wi-Fi models, but going forward the Wi-Fi demand is growing. So, in the near future, Wi-Fi printers will become the default printer at home. Further, now we have an application called Epson Smart Panel where you can control the printer using your smartphone device. The integration of the printer, not just with your laptops or desktops, but also with your smartphones or even smart assistants such as Alexa will happen in the future.

These kinds of connectivity enhancements will develop and improve as a default feature in the coming years. As people are moving from non Wi-Fi models, they will also move to control their printers with Smart Panels.

Q With regards to printing technology are people preferring more of the Ink Tank variety or are they still going with Cartridge devices?

Ink Tank as a category is growing very much in the market mainly because of its advantage over other technologies. First and foremost, the concept of Ink Tank, was developed by the Seiko Epson Corporation. In 2011 January we introduced it in India. Since then, it slowly removed the ink cartridge domination in the home segment. Currently, if you see it's less than 20 per cent.

Within the inkjet technology, we have two concepts – ink tank and ink cartridge. Before the ink tank revolution, only ink cartridges were sold. But after the introduction of Ink Tank, the ink cartridge is just contributing to less than 25 per cent, 75 per cent of the market is now dominated by Ink Tank technology. So this is within the inkjet technology. The other one is compared to the laser printer. If you see the laser printer, it was at 1.8 million units/year before the ink tank was introduced. Now if you see the laser printer market has come down to 1.3 million units/year whereas the ink tank market has gone up to 1.5 million units/year.

As a whole, whether it's home or office environment, the Ink tank printer or the Ink Tank concept is accelerating in terms of its own growth. The main reason is the cost of printers when compared to a laser printer or with the ink cartridge models. The second one is the high-yield ink bottles wherein the ink cartridge gives 400 or 200 pages per cartridge and even a laser printer i.e. within the sub-20 PPM category will see 2000 pages per toner cartridge. But an Epson ink bottle gives about 4500 in terms of L-series printers on entry-level models and if you talk about the mono-series then it gives about 6000 pages. And the cost per print is maintained. So on the economy front, it is much better than ink cartridges and laser printers. **Q**